

to train new team members in the new style of working that they mastered in the original sandbox.

Ideally, the sandbox will grow over time; that is, rather than move the team out of the sandbox and into the company's standard routines, there may be opportunities to enlarge the scope of the sandbox. For example, if only certain aspects of the product were subject to experimentation in the sandbox, new features can be added. In the online service described earlier, this could be accomplished by starting with a sandbox that encompassed the product pricing page. When those experiments succeeded, the company could add the website's home page to the sandbox. It subsequently might add the search functionality or the overall web design. If only certain customers or certain numbers of customers were targeted initially, the product's reach could be increased. When such changes are contemplated, it's important that senior management consider whether the teams working in the sandbox can fend for themselves politically in the parent organization. The sandbox was designed to protect them and the parent organization, and any expansion needs to take this into account.

Working in the innovation sandbox is like developing startup muscles. At first, the team will be able to take on only modest experiments. The earliest experiments may fail to produce much learning and may not lead to scalable success. Over time, those teams are almost guaranteed to improve as long as they get the constant feedback of small-batch development and actionable metrics and are held accountable to learning milestones.

Of course, any innovation system eventually will become the victim of its own success. As the sandbox expands and the company's revenue grows as a result of the sandbox's innovations, the cycle will have to begin again. The former innovators will become guardians of the status quo. When the product makes up the whole sandbox, it inevitably will become encumbered with the additional rules and controls needed for mission-critical operation. New innovation teams will need a new sandbox within which to play.